that I would be walking with Rahul on the Yatra and would get a few minutes to talk to him too.

I was on cloud nine by then, even though I was a bit sceptical about the whole thing. Was it really that easy to meet Rahul Gandhi? Is he really that approachable? I was probably just in disbelief, but my mind was abuzz with questions as I drove feverishly towards Nanded.

Upon reaching the Yatra, I half expected to be left out to dry. But I was promptly directed towards Pushparaj Deshpande, who was managing the civil society interactions for the Maharashtra leg of the Bharat Jodo Yatra. Putting my mind at ease, he took me to rest at one of the camps set up by the Congress party for participants. They were modest but adequate arrangements. There were clean and neat mobile toilets set up in vans, and two huge tents—one for resting and the other for food. But what struck me was how vibrant the whole place was. It was a vast mobile college on politics and society, and everyone was animatedly engaged in deep conversations. Anyone could join, and everyone was just so accommodating of everyone. As I was soaking it all in, Pushparaj gently told me, ‘Please rest well. It’s going to be rather hectic.’ But I couldn’t sleep a wink.

I was so excited that I stayed up, keeping the camp’s main entrance within eyesight so as not to miss the flag-off when the time came. Meanwhile, I could see Congress volunteers efficiently guiding people for lunch, escorting people to the resting areas, giving people medical help if they needed and even singing patriotic songs on a stereo system. I was soon joined by Nagorao Zapate, whom Pushparaj had deputed to chaperone me. Wondering where Pushparaj himself was, I saw him at a distance, animatedly engaged in a discussion with Digvijaya Singh and Jairam Ramesh. I was pleasantly surprised to see the two senior leaders engaging with him with ease and warmth, as one does with colleagues joined in a shared enterprise. I then began spotting other well-known Congress leaders such as Satej Patil and Kanhaiya Kumar chit-chatting with those who were in the camp. This was the first time I was seeing them off-screen and they looked so … human. No airs, no pretensions. Just simple, next-door guys keenly talking to everyone.